

Session 2: The Formation of the Gospels

Key Takeaways

- The Gospels are carefully designed theological biographies of Jesus that focus on his announcement of the good news about the arrival of God's Kingdom here on Earth.
- The gospel accounts are not merely historical records; they are designed to advance a claim that will challenge the reader's thinking, loyalties, and behavior.
- The four gospel accounts offer different perspectives and carry different emphases. But from the beginning of the Jesus movement, these differences have been celebrated as providing a fuller portrait of the good news about Jesus through their unity and diversity.

What Are the Gospels?

They are carefully designed theological biographies of Jesus that focus on his announcement of the good news about the arrival of God's Kingdom here on Earth. The gospel accounts are not merely historical records but are designed to advance a claim that will challenge the reader's thinking, loyalties, and behavior: The crucified and risen Jesus of Nazareth is the Son of David, that is, the Messiah of Israel, and the Son of God, that is, the divine Lord of the world. The gospel narratives (1) claim to faithfully represent the story of Jesus and (2) aim to persuade the reader to acknowledge Jesus as Lord and enter a community of his apprentices.

The titles of the four works tell us much about their purpose: "The Gospel according to ____." This tells us that Jesus' story is being framed in a unique way by each author for distinct purposes. We have evidence that these titles were being used in the early 2nd century C.E. to distinguish the gospel manuscripts from each other.

- For more on titles of the gospels in early New Testament manuscripts, see James Kelhoffer, "[How Soon a Book Revisited: ΕΥΑΓΓΕΛΙΟΝ as a Reference to Gospel Materials in the First Half of the Second Century](#)," in *Zeitschrift für Neutestamentliche Wissenschaft* vol. 95 (2004), p. 1-34.

Calling these books "the Gospels" derives from Mark's usage of the word in [Mark 1:1](#) "The beginning of **the good news** about Jesus the Messiah, the Son of God."

The Gospel and Ancient Biography

The Gospels are a kind of ancient biography.

- See the work of Richard Burridge, [What Are the Gospels? A Comparison with Greco-Roman Biography](#), and Loveday Alexander, [The Preface to Luke's Gospel](#).

Biographies in the ancient world were:

- Representations of the essence/meaning of a key figure's life story and message
- Not archival, unbiased accounts but accounts aimed at persuading the reader to emulate the figure

“The four apostolic Gospels are theological, historical, and formational, narrative biographies that retell the story and proclaim the significance of Jesus as Israel’s messiah and the Lord of all nations, the one who through the power of the Spirit is restoring God’s reign over all creation.”

Pennington, Jonathan (2012). [Reading the Gospels Wisely](#). Baker Academic. 35.

The Formation of the Gospels

Events and Teachings ↘	4 B.C.–80s/90s A.D. — Jesus’ early life, mission in Galilee, teaching and healing, mission to Jerusalem, execution, empty tomb, resurrection appearances, Pentecost
Eye-Witness Testimony ↘	4 B.C.–80s/90s A.D. — The earliest communities of Jesus’ followers contained eyewitnesses, friends and family members of Jesus' disciples, people healed by Jesus, and those who encountered Jesus.
Oral Traditions and Written Traditions ↘	30 A.D.–mid 2nd century A.D. — Jesus’ teaching and stories about him circulated in church communities for decades
Collections of Traditions ↘	40s A.D.–70s A.D. — Collections of traditions grouped together in oral and written form (“Q” or special material in Matthew, Luke, early Mark)
Gospel Compositions	60s–90s A.D. — Mark, Matthew, Luke, John, extra-canonical gospel traditions (Gospel of Peter, Gospel of Thomas, etc.)

The Formation of the Gospels. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).

For more detail on each stage of this important process, see the work of:

- Michael Bird, [The Gospel of the Lord: How the Early Church Wrote the Story of Jesus](#)
- James D.G. Dunn, [The Oral Gospel Tradition](#)
- Martin Hengel, [The Four Gospels and the One Gospel of Jesus Christ](#)

Main Theories of the Relationship Between the Synoptic Gospels

Charts adapted from Mark Goodacre, [The Synoptic Problem: A Way Through the Maze](#)

Priority of Mark Theories

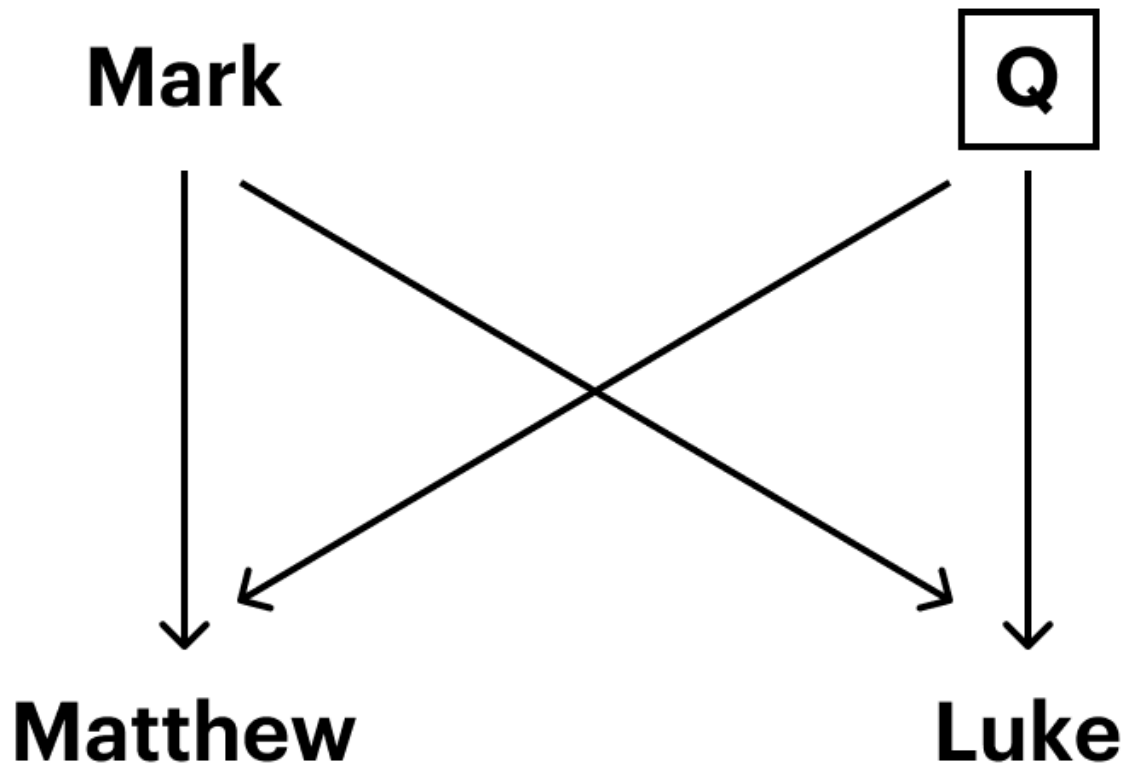


Fig. 1. The Two-Source Theory

The Two Source Theory. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).

The Two-Source Theory (Mark + “Q” + Special Matthew/Luke)

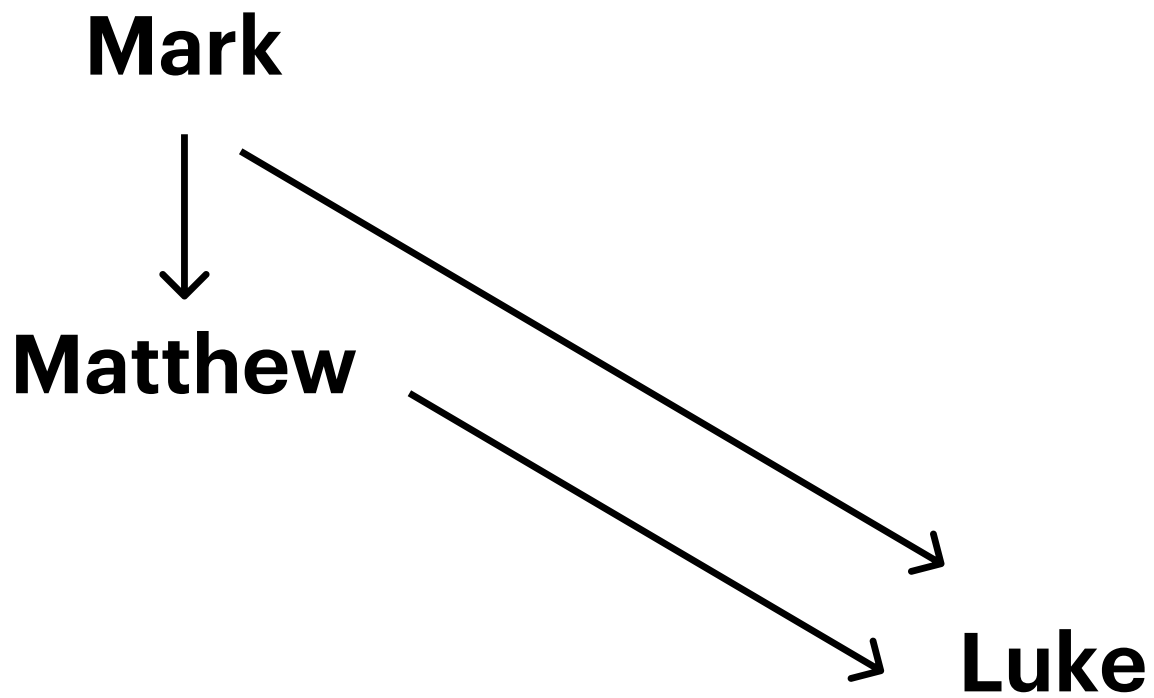


Fig. 2. The Farrer Theory

The Farrer Theory. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).

The Farrer Theory (Mark + Matthew used by Luke)

Priority of Matthew Theory

Matthew

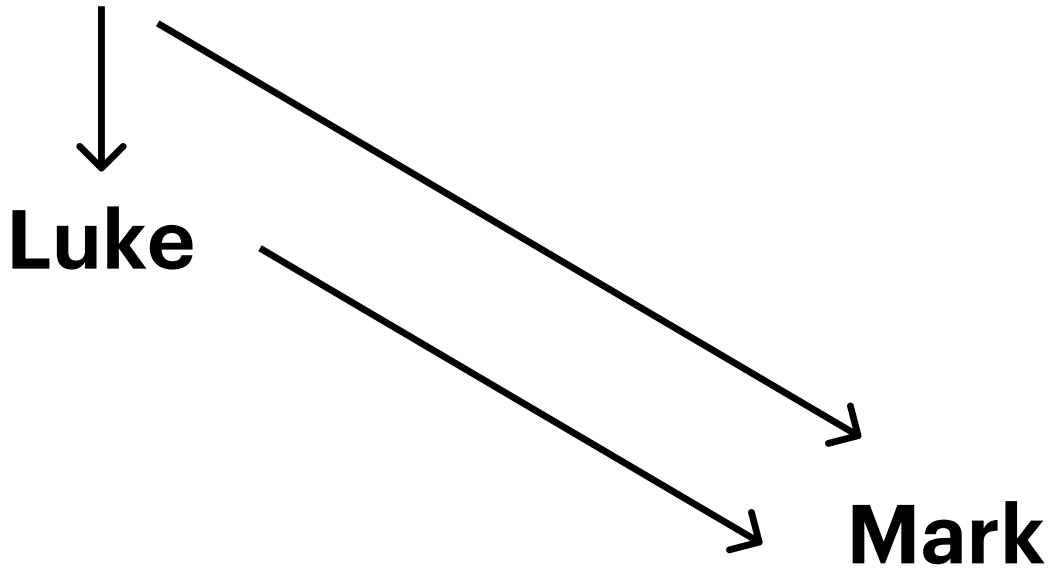


Fig. 3. The Griesbach Theory

The Griesbach Theory. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).

The Griesbach Theory (Matthew was the source of Luke, both abbreviated by Mark)

Reflection Question

What is challenging for you about the differences in the four gospel accounts? What is encouraging or helpful?